

Chapter 23_1 - Divorce Certificate

Until she walked out of the office door with that dark red booklet¹ clutched in her hand, Yan Lin was still in a daze.

Yan Lin stared blankly at the red-background ID photo inside that now showed only herself, and suddenly a tremendous sense of panic arose from the bottom of her heart.

It seemed like once she stepped out of the Civil Affairs Bureau² doors, there would be no possibility of reconciliation between her and Feng Yue.

So, almost subconsciously, Yan Lin reached out and grabbed Feng Yue's wrist, just like she had countless times before.

Yan Lin's gaze fell on Feng Yue's fingers, which were empty, with nothing on them.

"The ring..."

Feng Yue lowered her gaze to look at the hand with which Yan Lin was holding her, and at the simple ring on her ring finger that had once been filled with love.

She bit her lip, broke free from Yan Lin's grasp, and stood steadily in front of Yan Lin, saying: "Miss Yan, since you mentioned the ring, please return it to me."

Feng Yue's cold and distant voice suddenly rang in Yan Lin's ears. Yan Lin looked up, staring blankly into those eyes that held no emotion whatsoever.

"Since we're divorced, there's no need for the wedding rings to exist anymore. Don't you think so?"

Yan Lin couldn't speak. Her throat felt blocked, unable to utter a single word. She just felt that the person in front of her was very strange, very distant, not at all like her A-Yue³.

Already not fully recovered, Yan Lin was stimulated by this, and her face became even paler, even staggering back two steps.

Mo Yixu quickly reached out to support Yan Lin's arm, preventing their boss from actually falling to the ground.

Feng Yue frowned, looking at Yan Lin whose complexion had suddenly changed. She didn't think her few words could cause such harm to Yan Lin, so she habitually looked up inquiringly at Mo Yixu.

And Mo Yixu's answer came out subconsciously: "President Yan was ill for several days and only just recovered enough to get out of bed today."

As soon as the words fell, both the speaker and the listener were stunned.

After a long while, Feng Yue turned her head away somewhat vexedly, no longer looking at the pale-faced Yan Lin.

Mo Yixu also supported his boss, not knowing what to say for a moment.

After thinking for a moment, Feng Yue still turned around, took Yan Lin's hand with the ring on it with one hand, looked directly at her, and said lightly: "I'll take the ring."

With that, her other hand removed the ring from Yan Lin's ring finger.

Everything happened too quickly, causing the dizzy Yan Lin to have no time to react. By the time she wanted to grab Feng Yue, she only managed to touch a corner of her clothing.

"A-Yue..."

Feng Yue put the divorce certificate in her bag, clutched the ring in her hand, and walked straight out of the Civil Affairs Bureau doors.

Feng Yue stopped in front of a trash can and took out her own ring from her bag. Looking at the two rings nestled together in her palm, Feng Yue felt a mixture of emotions.

After a moment, a light sigh was carried away by the passing breeze, and two crisp sounds rang out as the rings fell into the trash can.

Thrown away—everything related to Yan Lin had been thrown away.

Yan Lin had just chased out of the Civil Affairs Bureau doors when she saw Feng Yue casually throw something into the trash can.

Yan Lin seemed nailed to the spot, unable to hear anything for a moment except the crisp sound of the rings falling into the trash can.

Yan Lin pushed away Mo Yixu's supporting hand, quickly stepped down the stairs, and stumbled toward the trash can.

Perhaps because the sanitation worker had just cleaned the garbage, there were only the two rings that Feng Yue had thrown in the trash can.

But the grime accumulated in the trash can over the years was not to be underestimated either—those two clean rings just lay there quietly.

The next second, Mo Yixu saw his boss, without any regard for anything else, reach into the trash can to retrieve the two rings and clutch them tightly in her hand.

People were coming and going on the walkway, and passersby all cast strange looks at Yan Lin. Why would a cleanly dressed young woman be rummaging through a trash can!

Even Mo Yixu, who was used to big scenes, wished he could disappear on the spot at this moment, but Yan Lin paid no attention to any of this.

At this moment, her eyes held only those two rings.

Why could clean things be so mercilessly thrown into a trash can by Feng Yue? Yan Lin thought to herself.

Didn't she know the answer?

She did.

Only useless things would be thrown away like garbage, and at this moment, these two rings were just that to Feng Yue—garbage.

This matter-of-fact thought pierced her heart like a poisoned dagger, the toxin spreading, blood flowing like a river.

How Yan Lin finally got home, she could no longer remember. She only knew that the things in her hands were dirty and needed to be washed.

Perhaps once they were clean, Feng Yue would no longer throw them away like garbage.

Yan Lin's mother looked at the tightly closed bathroom door, listening to the almost continuous sound of running water inside, her eyes reddening again and again.

Assistant Mo had already told her what had happened, and seeing her child's current condition, Yan Lin's mother could only sigh sadly at the tricks of fate.

At this moment, Yan Lin, who was staying in the bathroom, was silently and stubbornly washing the two rings in her palm with clean water.

She was slightly bent over, her fingers constantly scrubbing the spotless rings, but her mind was filled with the scene of Feng Yue casually throwing them away and turning to leave.

Each time she thought about it, the dagger piercing her heart would thrust an inch deeper. Her teeth bit tightly on her lower lip, and her originally bloodless lips were bitten until they showed an eerie red.

The tears that had been swirling in her eye sockets finally rolled down during one of her blinks, dripping onto her arm. The temperature of the tears was so hot it made her arm tremble slightly.

Yan Lin's mother stood anxiously outside the door, wanting to knock but afraid of disturbing Yan Lin. The sound of running water inside had never stopped, and her heart couldn't rest for a moment.

"Madam, should we use the key to force the door open? The young miss has just recovered from a serious illness, and her emotional fluctuations are so great—I'm afraid she won't be able to hold on." Standing next to Yan Lin's mother was Aunt Yang⁴, the nanny who had watched Yan Lin grow up since childhood.

Yan Lin's mother thought for a moment, gritted her teeth, and stamped her foot, nodding. However, before Aunt Yang could get the key, the sound of water inside stopped.

The next second, Yan Lin inside the door met eyes with Yan Lin's mother, who had been guarding outside.

Yan Lin seemed unwilling to let her mother see her red-rimmed eyes, so she turned her head to the side and said hoarsely: "Mom, I'm tired."

After saying this, Yan Lin clutched the things in her hands and walked straight upstairs, paying no attention to the people left behind.

Yan Lin returned to her room and sat quietly by the bedside for a while, then went to the walk-in closet to find a thin, simple silver chain to string the two rings on, wearing it around her neck.

The cool touch against her warm chest finally gave her a feeling of coming back to life.

Yan Lin reached out and tightly grasped the rings hanging on her chest. She couldn't just compromise and give up like this. She had to fight for what she wanted.

Just like the original Feng Yue.

She had liked her and pursued her relentlessly for twelve years. If she didn't want to give up Feng Yue, she could do the same.

Of course, all of this had to be based on her ability to take action, and the current Yan Lin obviously did not have this capability.

Having experienced another upheaval, Yan Lin was again struck down by the high fever that hadn't been completely suppressed. The Yan family's old mansion had another sleepless night.

After throwing away the rings, although Feng Yue still felt somewhat upset, more than that was the relief of letting go of all constraints.

Those rings had a different meaning for her, but their destination at this moment could only be the trash can.

Feng Yue got out of the car with her bag, and when she reached the elevator at the bottom of her residential building, she suddenly saw a familiar figure.

"Xiao Xue⁵?" Feng Yue looked in surprise at the figure currently crouching under her apartment building, with a security guard nearby eyeing her warily.

Fu Sixue was wearing a sports jacket with a pleated skirt on the bottom half, her yellowing long hair scattered down. Crouching there, she looked exactly like a stray cat.

"Little Moon⁶, you finally came back!" Fu Sixue said with a mournful face. When she tried to stand up, she discovered that her legs had gone numb from crouching too long.

Fu Sixue swayed unsteadily, "Quick, quick, quick, help me up! I'm going to fall!"

Feng Yue quickly stepped forward to support her, then asked: "Why did you suddenly come to find me?"

"Of course to care about you!" Fu Sixue said, shaking the things she was carrying in her hand.

Feng Yue reached out to take the bag from her, "What are you carrying? Such a big bag. Also, why didn't you call me when you arrived?"

Fu Sixue pulled out her phone from her bag with one hand and smiled, "Dead battery."

Feng Yue: ...

"Admirable!" Feng Yue supported her with one hand and carried the bag with the other as they walked into the elevator together.

"I just finished a batch of design drafts recently, so I finally had time to come see you," Fu Sixue said. "I heard about your illness. Is everything alright?"

Feng Yue was startled at the words—it was obvious where she had heard this from. "It's fine. I'm recovering very well now, and I don't even need surgery."

"That's good, that's good. But if you need any overseas medical resources, just contact me. My old man⁷ isn't good at other things, but he has many connections in this area."

Feng Yue nodded. She seemed to have heard that Fu Sixue's family was in the medical field.

"By the way, the things in that bag are all health supplements recommended by my old man. Take a look—eat them if you can, and if not, just leave them there. I'll bring you something else next time."

Feng Yue smiled with curved eyebrows, "Then thank you very much, Dr. Fu!"

"Stop teasing me! I don't want to be a doctor!"

The two took the elevator to Feng Yue's front door. After resting for a while, Fu Sixue finally no longer needed to be supported like a disabled person.

"You go charge your phone. The charger is over by the TV cabinet. I'll get you something to drink." Feng Yue put down the things and went to pour water for Fu Sixue.

Fu Sixue happily gave her phone some life, and only then had time to think about Feng Yue and Yan Lin's situation.

Looking at Feng Yue's back as she poured water, she tentatively asked: "Little Moon, are you... planning to divorce A-Lin?"

Feng Yue's back stiffened, but she didn't speak.

Fu Sixue sensed something was wrong and quickly tried to make amends, "Let me clarify first! I'm not here to persuade you! After talking with A-Lin that day, I also think she did wrong. I almost wanted to beat her up! I'm asking you now just to care about you. Even if you two break up, we were still high school classmates for a year!"

Feng Yue smiled slightly, turned around with the glass, and said: "What would you fight her for?"

"Also, I'm not planning to divorce her," Feng Yue raised her eyebrows slightly and said clearly, "We already have."

"The divorce certificate is right there in my bag if you don't believe me."

Footnotes:

¹ In China, divorce certificates are small red booklets, similar to marriage certificates but with different text and formatting.

² The Civil Affairs Bureau (民政局) is the government office in China where marriages and divorces are officially registered and processed.

³ "A-Yue" (阿月) is an intimate nickname formed by adding the prefix "A" (阿) to someone's name, typically used by close family members or romantic partners.

⁴ "Aunt Yang" (杨婶) - "Shen" (婶) is a respectful term used for older women who work in the household, similar to "Auntie" but specifically for domestic staff.

⁵ "Xiao Xue" (小雪) - "Xiao" (小) meaning "little/small" is a common affectionate prefix for nicknames, showing closeness.

⁶ "Little Moon" (小月亮) - This is Fu Sixue's special nickname for Feng Yue, playing on the "Yue" (月) character in her name which means "moon."

⁷ "Old man" (老头子) - A familiar, somewhat affectionate way to refer to one's father, though it can sound slightly disrespectful in formal contexts.